

for the return journey. Along the way, depots were built at regular intervals for the animals and drivers to rest. Although the existence of this network is not certain, it is evident that the origin of railways in India lies in the knowledge that movement of vehicles on a set path reduces the amount of human effort that may be required otherwise.

Little labour, huge gains

The first rail line was laid as an experiment near the Chintadripet Bridge in the Madras Presidency in 1836. The experiment included moving a cart loaded with stones up an inclined plane by hand to show how, with little labour, it rolled down to its source by its own weight. This line was later merged with the permanent line of the Red Hill Railway. A British General and engineer, [Sir AT Cotton](#), who was appointed to inspect the areas near Madras, noted that the construction of rails to the Red Hills and to the stone quarries at Little Mount would save nearly half of the annual expenditure on carrying material along the roads. It would also bring in profits through the line's use by private traders. His recommendations were approved, and thus began the work of laying down possibly the first rail line in the Indian subcontinent.